changing a profile picture while remaining indoors. But it is the potential to mobilize and express dissent where the audience is global that has caused the internet and social media sites such as Facebook to become dangerous.

The potential of social media in Pakistan

Obar and Wildman (2015) have argued that 'as social media services further integrate into our societal systems and personal lives, scholars, advocates and policymakers must continue to wrestle with the extent to which legal and regulatory innovations can ensure the protections and freedoms that will at certain points harness and at other points reign in the transformative possibilities implicit in social media" (p. 749). In Pakistan, the potential of social media – to ignite debate and discussion, to challenge the state narrative on Pakistaniat, to translate into real-world action – is far from being harnessed. While organizations such as the Digital Rights Foundation, along with human rights activists, journalists and civil society members, have resisted and challenged the state by bringing international attention to the issue of freedom of speech and rights online, such actions have been successful only to a limited extent. PECA 2016 was implemented with limited changes, and continues to curtail any form of activism online, with the situation only worsening as the existing government clamps down on dissent that is perceived to be against the state, the army or Islam, that is, the national narrative. Yusaf (2015) describes 'cyberspace' in Pakistan as 'increasingly' reflecting 'the polarization and intolerance that plagues Pakistani society' (2015, p. 172). She gives the example of the reaction to the assassination of the Governor of Punjab Salman Taseer by his bodyguard Mumtaz Qadri 'on account of his support for amending Pakistan's controversial blasphemy laws'. The reaction on Facebook included people who condemned Qadri and those who celebrated his actions by creating and supporting (through 'likes') Facebook pages celebrating him. When those pages were reported by Facebook users as hate speech and banned, those same Qadri supporters replaced their profile pictures with his photograph to show their support (Yusaf 2015, pp. 172–3). The online space therefore reflects the offline reality, an uneven contest for a narrative about Pakistan that the military state and right-wing (often militant) groups dominate, where human rights activists, even politically active citizens who take part in movements such as the PTM, are labelled rogue elements of an 'engineered protest'.[16]

The most dangerous aspect of this surveillance of social media activity is the reinforcement of the blasphemy laws, where citizens are being encouraged to report on fellow citizens who have committed blasphemy online. In Pakistan